ELECTIONS 2023

POLLPOURRI

So Who's Soorma Bhopali?

Vast, open prairies overrun by dacoits with bad teeth, a script-writer from Indore in Salim Khan, a teenager getting a job in a bidi factory in Jabalpur... though it was never mentioned explicitly, Madhya Pradesh is writ all over the 1975 blockbuster *Sholay*. Now the Thakur's ghost seems to be haunting the poll-bound state all over again. Congress sharpshooter Randeep Surjewala has deemed it fitting that the party's chief campaigners, Kamal 'Roly' Nath and Digvijay 'Diggy raja' Singh be rechristened 'Jai and Veeru'. The BJP, miffed by the flattering analogy, immediately pounced on the fact that Jai-Veeru were partners-in-crime! But then they changed tack. Union minister Narendra Singh Tomar, now in a bit of a spot with a purported video of his son going viral, said in all modesty that he and CM Shivraj Chouhan were the original Jai and Veeru. The Congress took the by-now-dismally-predictable game further and said Chouhan was actually Gabbar. Not to be left behind, the latter referenced another '70s movie—the Vinod Khanna-Shatrughan Sinha starrer *Mere Apne*—and said Diggy-Roly were more like the two competing ruffians in the film. Back in the Congress court now. ■



Photo Illustration by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY



DIYAS FOR DIYA KUMARI

Diya Kumari has taken to Vidyadhar Nagar constituency in Jaipur like fish to water. Or rather, like a Rajasthani to a plate of dal-baati-churma. It smells of home. She knows people, people know her. She was born seven months after her granddad—Man Singh II, the last ruling maharaja of Jaipur—passed away in 1970. Eleven months later, her dad Bhawani Singh lost even the titular status when royalty privileges were abolished in December 1971. So it had to be democracy. But Diya hasn't done too badly, winning from a new battlefield twice under a saffron flag. First, a tough skirmish at the Sawai Madhopur assembly seat in 2013. Then, as the party acceded to her request for a Lok Sabha ticket in 2019, a handsome conquest of Rajsamand. Now BJP state general secretary, she has got a 'safe seat', but her insertion wasn't without a bit of heat and smoke: she replaced sitting MLA Narpat Singh Rajvi, three-time winner, son-in-law of the late Bhairon Singh Shekhawat and, most of all, perceived of late as a Vasundhara Raje campwallah. Fight a maharani with a maharani? With all the reverence due to the ex-CM (who brought her into politics), she parries the query politely: "She's our senior leader, I have the utmost respect for her and can't be

-By **Rahul Noronha, Rohit Parihar and Amarnath K. Menon**